



Power BI Viewer

USER GUIDE

A friendly, complete guide to viewing your reports,
dashboards, and wall-display slideshows.

For everyday users • No technical knowledge needed

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1. Welcome — what this app is

Power BI Viewer is a desktop app for Windows and Mac that lets you open and view your organization's Power BI reports and dashboards in one tidy window. You can search for anything quickly, run a hands-free slideshow on a wall display, export what you are looking at to a PDF, and switch between Microsoft 365 accounts — all without needing to open a web browser.

2. Getting started — launching and signing in

To open the app, double-click the **Power BI Viewer** icon on your desktop or in your Applications list, just like any other program.

The first time you open it:

1. You will see a welcome window with the **Power BI Viewer** logo.
2. Click the **Sign in with Microsoft** button.
3. A Microsoft sign-in window appears. Enter your normal work email and password (and approve any verification prompt your organization uses).
4. Once you are signed in, the app opens to the Home screen.

Good news: you usually sign in only once

Your sign-in is remembered between sessions. The next time you open Power BI Viewer, it normally takes you straight to the Home screen — you won't be asked to pick your account every time.

If something goes wrong while signing in, a red **Sign in failed** message appears. Simply click **Sign in with Microsoft** again to retry.

3. Finding your way around

The Home screen

Home greets you by name (for example, "Good morning, Sam") and is your launch pad. Depending on what you have opened before, you may see:

- **Featured Workspaces** — a short row of workspaces you can open.
- A **Browse Workspaces** button to see everything you have access to.
- A **Frequent** row — the items you open most often.
- A **Recent** list — the items you opened most recently.
- A **Refresh** button (top right) to reload this list.

The first time you use the app, these lists are empty. Click **Browse Workspaces** to find your first report — items you open will start appearing on Home for quick access.

The sidebar (left edge)

The narrow strip down the left side is how you move between the main areas. It has four buttons:

Button	What it shows
Home	Your greeting, recent and frequent items.
Workspaces	All the workspaces you can access, and the reports and dashboards inside them.
Apps	The Power BI apps published to you.
Settings	All app preferences (at the bottom of the sidebar).

You can make the sidebar wider or narrower using the toggle button at its top. When it is narrow it shows just icons; hover over an icon to see its name. The area you are currently in is marked with a small orange line on its left.

The title bar (top of the window)

Across the very top you will find:

- The app logo and name on the left.
- A **Search reports and dashboards...** box in the middle (covered in the next section).
- Your **account avatar** on the right — a small circle with your initials. Next to it, a colored badge may show your organization's domain.

Click your avatar to open the account menu, where you can **Switch account** or **Sign out**.

4. Searching for a report or dashboard

Search is the fastest way to find anything.

1. Press **Ctrl** + **K** (on a Mac, **Cmd** + **K**). You can also click the search box at the top of the window.
2. Start typing the name of what you want. The box reads **Search reports, dashboards, apps, and workspaces...**
3. Results appear instantly as you type, each labelled by type — **Report**, **Dashboard**, **App**, or **Workspace** — and showing which workspace it lives in.
4. Click a result to open it, or use the keyboard: **↑** **↓** to move, **Enter** to open, **Esc** to close.

Tip

If you see "No results found", check your spelling or try a shorter word. To clear the box and start over, click the small **×** at the right of the search field.

5. Viewing a report

Open a report from Home, from Workspaces, or from search. It fills the window, with a toolbar across the top. Here is what each toolbar item does:

Toolbar item	What it does
Back	Returns to the previous screen (or Home). The report name is also shown as a breadcrumb: Home > (report name) .
Data refreshed: (date & time)	Shows when the underlying data was last refreshed in Power BI, so you know how current the figures are.

Refresh	Reloads the report with the latest data. While it works, the button reads Refreshing...
Export PDF	Saves the current view as a PDF file (see Section 9). While it works it reads Exporting...
Slideshow	Starts a hands-free presentation of this report (see Section 8).
Full screen (corner-arrows icon)	Expands the report to fill your whole screen. Press ESC or click the icon again to leave full screen.

Moving between report pages in full screen

Many reports have several pages. When you are in full screen and a report has more than one page, use the  and  arrow keys to move between pages. A small hint in the corner shows which page you are on (for example, "2 / 5").

Filters and slicers

Reports keep their normal Power BI filters and page navigation, so you can interact with the report exactly as you would on the web.

6. Viewing a dashboard

Dashboards work much like reports, with a toolbar offering **Back**, the **Data refreshed**: time, **Refresh**, **Export PDF**, and **Full screen**.

Click a tile to dig deeper

A dashboard is made of tiles. Click any tile to open the full report behind it, so you can explore the detail. Use **Back** to return to the dashboard.

About the "Data refreshed" time on dashboards

A dashboard can pull data from several sources, so this time reflects the oldest data on the dashboard — your safest "is anything stale?" signal. If no refresh time is available, the app simply hides it rather than show a misleading value.

Note: the **Slideshow** button is available for reports, not for dashboards.

7. Viewing an app

An **app** is a published collection of reports and dashboards bundled together. Open one from the **Apps** area in the sidebar or from search. The app opens in the full Power BI experience inside the window.

Its toolbar has two items:

- **Back to Apps** — returns you to the Apps list.
- **Refresh** — reloads the app.

Navigate within the app using its own menus, just as you would on the Power BI website.

8. Slideshow & wall-display (kiosk) mode

Slideshow mode plays a report automatically, advancing through its pages (or bookmarks) on a timer. It is perfect for a TV or monitor on the wall.

Starting a slideshow yourself

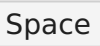
1. Open a report.
2. Click **Slideshow** in the toolbar.
3. The report fills the screen and begins cycling through slides.

The on-screen controls

Move your mouse to bring up the controls (they fade away after a few seconds while playing). You will see:

- **Exit** (top-left) — leaves the slideshow.
- A slide counter showing the current slide name and position, e.g. "(3 / 8)".
- A **Settings** (gear) button to change how fast slides advance.
- **Play / Pause** in the centre, with **Previous slide** and **Next slide** arrows either side.
- A row of dots (or a slider, for very long decks) showing your position. Click a dot to jump to that slide.

Keyboard shortcuts during a slideshow

Key	Action
 or 	Next slide
	Previous slide
	Play or pause
	Exit a slideshow you started yourself (see exit box below)

★ How to exit a slideshow

If you started the slideshow yourself (by clicking **Slideshow**):

- Press  once. That's it.

If the slideshow started on its own (a wall display set up to run automatically — "kiosk" mode): a single  is ignored on purpose, so the display can't be knocked off by an accidental key press. To exit, do *either* of these:

- Hold down  for 3 seconds, or
- Press  +  + .

A small reminder always sits in the **bottom-right corner** of the screen showing these exit steps, so help is always on screen even when nobody is around.

Unattended wall displays

When running on a wall display, the app keeps the screen awake so it won't go dark, and if a slide ever fails to load it quietly tries again on its own. You can leave it running unattended.

Auto-start on launch

A wall display can be set up to jump straight into a chosen report's slideshow the moment the app opens. That is configured under **Settings** (see Section 10: "Launch on Startup" and "Auto-start slideshow").

9. Exporting to PDF

You can save what you are viewing as a PDF — handy for emailing or printing.

1. Open the report or dashboard you want.
2. Click **Export PDF** in the toolbar.
3. A **Save** window opens. Choose where to save the file. It defaults to your **Downloads** folder with a name like **powerbi-export-....pdf** — you can rename it or pick another folder.
4. The button shows **Exporting...** while it works. When it finishes you will see **Exported to PDF** in the toolbar (or a short error message if something went wrong, in which case just try again).

Tip

The PDF captures the view as you have it set up — the current page and any filters or bookmarks applied — so set the report up the way you want it before exporting.

10. Settings explained

Open **Settings** from the bottom of the sidebar. Settings are grouped into cards. Here is every setting in plain language.

Account

Shows your name and email, with a **Sign out** button.

Appearance

Theme — choose how the app looks: **Light**, **Dark**, or **System** (matches your computer's setting). Changes apply immediately.

Slideshow / Presentation Mode

Setting	What it does
Auto-advance interval	How long each slide stays on screen before moving on. Slide the control anywhere from 5 seconds to 5 minutes .
Slideshow mode	What counts as a "slide": Pages only , Bookmarks only , or Pages and bookmarks .
Auto-start slideshow	When On , opening a report in slideshow begins playing automatically. This is what makes a wall display "kiosk" mode (where exit needs the 3-second Esc hold or Ctrl + Shift + Q).

Launch on Startup

Setting	What it does
Startup behavior	Choose Show home screen (the normal choice) or Open a specific report when the app launches.
Report to open at launch	Appears when you choose "Open a specific report". Pick from your recently and frequently opened reports. (If the list is empty, open a few reports first, then return here.)

Data Refresh

Setting	What it does
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Auto-refresh reports	When On , open reports reload their data on a timer so figures stay current — useful for wall displays.
Refresh interval	Appears when auto-refresh is on. How often to refresh, from 1 minute to 2 hours .

Usage History

Setting	What it does
Clear usage history on sign-out	Controls when your Recent and Frequent lists are cleared: Never (keep them), Always , or On shared machine (use this if several people sign in to the same device).
Clear usage history now	Immediately empties the Recent and Frequent sections on Home.

Reset

Reset all settings to defaults — puts every setting back to how it started. Your sign-in is not affected.

About

Shows the app's **version number**. Click **Check for updates** to open the releases page in your web browser, where you can see if a newer version is available.

11. Tips & keyboard shortcuts

Anywhere in the app

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl + K (Cmd + K on Mac)	Open search

In search

Shortcut	Action
↑ ↓	Move between results
Enter	Open the highlighted result
Esc	Close search

Viewing a report in full screen

Shortcut	Action
← →	Move between report pages
Esc	Leave full screen

In a slideshow

Shortcut	Action
→ / Space	Next slide

	Previous slide
	Play / pause
	Exit (slideshow you started yourself)
Hold  3s or  +  + 	Exit an auto-started (kiosk) slideshow

12. Troubleshooting & FAQ

I'm stuck in a slideshow — how do I get out?

- If **you started it**: press  once.
- If it started **on its own** (a wall display): hold  for 3 seconds, or press  +  + .

A reminder of these steps always shows in the **bottom-right corner** of the screen.

A report won't load

If a report or dashboard shows an error message, click **Try again**. If it still won't open, you may not have access to it, or it may have been moved or removed — click **Back** to return Home and try a different item. Searching with  +  can help confirm the correct name.

I see the wrong account's items

You may be signed in with a different account than you expected. Click your **avatar** (top-right) and choose **Switch account** to pick the right one. To sign out entirely, choose **Sign out** — you'll be asked to confirm with the message "**Sign out?**".

It's asking me to sign in again

You normally stay signed in between sessions. If asked again, just click **Sign in with Microsoft** — this is normal after a long gap, a password change, or signing out.

The screen went to sleep on the wall display

While a slideshow runs, the app keeps the display awake automatically. If it still sleeps, the cause is usually the monitor's or computer's own power settings — confirm the slideshow is playing, and have whoever set up the display check those settings.

How do I change how fast slides advance?

Two ways:

- **During a slideshow**: move the mouse to show the controls, click the **Settings** (gear) button, and drag the **Interval** slider.
- **Before a slideshow**: go to **Settings > Slideshow / Presentation Mode** and adjust **Auto-advance interval** (anywhere from 5 seconds to 5 minutes).

Still need help?

Contact whoever set up Power BI Viewer for your organization. Letting them know the app version (found in **Settings > About**) will help them assist you.